

PLAY WITH CLASS



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Welcome to **Play with Class**, where we will give you concrete steps to run each class for the world's greatest roleplaying game! I'm not sure about you, but I frequently find the sheer amount of character options exhausting to comb through. I often wish someone would highlight what will work the best when I play my shiny new character. And since I want it, I'm going to assume you all might find such a guide helpful as well. So here we are breaking it down. Now let's get to it.

BE A BRUTAL BARBARIAN

The barbarian has existed through many editions of the game and for good reason—they hit real hard, and when they hit, it hurts real bad. When I introduce new players to 5th Edition, I often recommend picking the barbarian as their first character class. Why? Because it's easy to learn the ropes, and running a barbarian in combat is instantly gratifying. Everyone loves the feeling of doing a billion damage in a single round of combat, and hooking new players with that success is a great way to keep them coming back to the table.

ROLE OF THE BARBARIAN

In a standard adventuring party, barbarians usually land in the DPS (damage per second) category, meaning that you are phenomenal at getting into the middle of combat and taking down enemies quickly. Barbarians can occasionally also take on the role of party tank (a character who can take big hits, so others don't have to) because of their high hit points, but other classes with access to heavy armor typically fit that role better.

Your job as the barbarian is to get right into the center of fights and bring down foes as quickly as possible.

REASONS TO PLAY A BARBARIAN

- Easy to play! You have a concise list of abilities to master before reaching your full potential.
- Your party will love you! Barbarians operating at their best deal massive amounts of damage per round. And even better, they consistently deal serious damage round after round. There is no “out of spell slots” problem for you.
- Clear motivations! Barbarians lend themselves to easy-to-understand character motivations, which makes them easier to roleplay. Usually, the goals you care about are straightforward, and the way you achieve those goals is even clearer.

COMBAT CRASH COURSE

So how do you run the damage-dealing juggernaut known as the barbarian? There are just a few tricks you have to master to get the most out of your abilities. Once you have these things on lock, your combat experience will be smooth sailing.

MASTER YOUR RAGE

The first-level feature, Rage, is the cornerstone of all your class capabilities. Your main goal is to remember to rage as soon as possible in combat. Don't forget to always start with that bonus action to rage! While raging, you are way better at hitting, resistant to all kinds of damage, and living your best warrior life. The only tricky thing about rage is that you have to stay engaged in combat to keep it going, which means if you are far away from your enemies, you should wait to rage until you get to the front lines. Admittedly though, situations that would end your rage rarely ever come up (unless you make poor tactical choices).

LIVE RECKLESSLY

The most challenging part of playing a barbarian is remembering to use your second level Reckless Attack feature. The faster you can learn to make use of the devastating ability, the happier you will be. Essentially, using this ability will give you an attack with advantage every single turn, which is mind-blowingly useful for all levels of play. The only downside in using this feature is that it gives your enemy advantage to retaliate. Honestly, you've likely already killed them with the attack before they ever get that chance. Learn to love the reckless life.

DO YOUR MATH AHEAD OF TIME

One of the greatest things about playing a barbarian is all the static bonuses you get from the class. Most of your abilities give you a flat advantage that you don't have to activate. They just work! This also means that you need to make sure your character sheet is updated with your information before you sit down to play. Make sure you write a big note that whenever you get hit with a trap, you get bonuses from Danger Sense. Make sure your movement speed is updated when you get the fast movement ability. Mark your advantage to initiative and extra damage die in big, highlighted notes. These flat bonuses make you awesome, and you will not have a good time if you don't have them marked on your sheet.



MECHANICAL PICKS

As you get more experience (literally) playing a barbarian, you'll take on the additional challenge of picking up mechanics to unlock even more potential. While there are, of course, an incredible number of options for you to choose from, I'm going to recommend a couple based on different play experiences you might want to have.

PURE DAMAGE SUBCLASS

If you want to continue experiencing the best the barbarian has to offer in terms of pure ferocious attack power, you've got to go Path of the Berserker. This subclass gets you a bonus attack right off the bat, keeps your head in the slaying game, and eventually gives you a reaction attack if the other three attacks weren't enough!

FLAVOR SAVOR

If you are looking for a barbarian that is a little spiritual and has high Wisdom, check out the Path of the Ancestors (see *Midgard Heroes Handbook*).

BUILD A BANGING BARD

Oh, bards. Is there any other class that has such a colorful reputation? Bards have seen a complicated evolution through the editions, primarily because they tend to fill a jack-of-all-trades adventuring role. Playing a bard guarantees that you'll have lots of fun flavor to play with at the table, but it can be challenging to feel like an effective combat force. For this reason, I usually steer new players away from choosing a bard. That said, if you have ever enjoyed an improv class, you are likely to have a massive amount of fun with this class, regardless of your gaming experience level.

ROLE OF THE BARD

In a standard adventuring party, bards usually land in the support category. Being support means that most of your abilities empower your allies and debuff your enemies. Support classes require a more subtle hand to play since they don't do well hacking away in the middle of a fray, and they don't have a wealth of damage-dealing spells to sling.

Your job as the bard is to cast your help or harm concentration spells as soon as possible and then keep doling out bonuses to your teammates every round.

REASONS TO PLAY A BARD

- You will be the best smoothest talker in the land. Seriously, your ability to persuade, charm, and inspire is unrivaled by any other class.
- You get to do a little bit of everything! You cast spells, you can hold your own in a fight, and you've got mad skills. You certainly won't ever feel like you're in a rut.
- You have opportunities to do everything creatively. Whether you want to cast spells as beat poetry or become a mime, it all works for a bard.

COMBAT CRASH COURSE

So, how do you play your boisterous bard in the throes of battle? Playing a bard is all about mastering your action economy. When you understand what abilities to use in each circumstance, you become a buffing and debuffing machine.

ALWAYS BE INSPIRING

The cornerstone of the bard class is their ability to dole out bardic inspiration. Bardic inspiration is an incredible asset for your allies to use, so you must master it. So many people forget to use their bardic inspiration and consequently experience lackluster

performance in combat. Giving an ally a bardic inspiration die is a bonus action, so unless you have something else specific to do as that bonus, you should give out that inspiration like candy. You're also always going to have more than enough uses left, especially after recovering them on short rests after 5th level. Just remember to end every turn by giving a bardic inspiration, and you are already miles ahead of other bardic players.

CHOOSE YOUR SPELLS WISELY

I'm not going to lie to you. Bards have it rough when it comes to spellcasting. The vast majority of great bard spells require concentration, which means you have to be ruthless about cultivating your spell list. You also need to keep your bonus actions mostly free to dole out bardic inspiration, narrowing your effective spell choices even further. All this means is that you have to be hyper-aware of your combat action economy. Typically you want to have a small selection of your





powerhouse concentration spells, get them going early, and then run a light offense with your weapons. Bards don't have great damage cantrips available from the get-go, so being capable with a ranged weapon, especially at early levels, is a must. When these basics are covered, you can use your remaining spells known for solid damage spells.

Things get a touch easier for bards when you start unlocking new spell options through magical secrets, but you have to set yourself up for spell success until 10th level. Also, keep in mind that the vast majority of offensive bard spells require Wisdom saving throws, which are straight up useless against many higher-level creatures (who are often immune to the charmed and frightened conditions). So whenever you see a new spell with a different kind of save, grab it! Diversify as much as you can, especially with your magical secret choices.

LEVEL-UP PICKS

The key to making a successful bard is to make strong choices and support those choices mechanically each level. Here are some level up tricks to keep in mind.

KNOW YOUR THEME

Bards can do so many different things that you end up being mediocre at everything if you don't firmly choose one path. When you first make your bard and pick your subclass, you must have a firm idea of what kind of bard you want to be. If you want to be mostly a spellcaster, if you want to be in the heart of combat, if you want to go all in on being a roguish performer or an inspiring leader, pick your college and spells to reflect that choice. The key here is to decide right off the bat what you are primarily going to do when playing your character and then stick to your guns.

DEXTERITY IS YOUR BEST FRIEND

Whether moving about the field to help your allies or maintaining concentration on your spells, it is in your best interest as a bard to not get hit. Because you have so many concentration spells going, you put your entire party in danger every time you have to make a roll to maintain a spell. Since heavy armor typically isn't your bag, Dexterity is going to be your ultimate best friend. Keep your Charisma and your Dexterity scores high, and you will be golden.

FLAVOR SAVOR

Consider these flavorful choices to emphasize your bardic style:

- If your bard has a green thumb and you want to focus on healing, check out the Greenleaf College subclass (*Deep Magic*).
- Remember, your bard doesn't have to use singing to cast their spells. Look at tool options available to you and talk to your GM about other possibilities. Storytelling, poetry, dance, flower arranging, painting, or any other artistic pursuit can work for your bardic flavor!

CRAFT A COOL CLERIC

The divine adventurers known as clerics have been kicking around since the earliest versions of the game. With the ability to wear armor, blast their foes with holy fury, and bring allies back from the dead, a cleric is always in demand. Clerics in 5th edition have a lot they can do, and this can make them an overwhelming class choice for a green player. If you choose to play a cleric, you are expected to keep your party alive, or you are expected to come up with an excellent reason why you don't. So new players, turn back! Cleric may not be the best class choice for you.

ROLE OF THE CLERIC

The cleric has traditionally filled the role of healer in a standard adventuring party. With so many spell choices geared toward healing, buffing, and regeneration, it takes a lot of work to break out of this prescribed mold. Clerics can, of course, fill other roles by picking up specialized subclasses and selecting different domains, but at the end of the day, you are just so much better at keeping everyone alive than any other class.

The cleric is the only core spellcasting class that gets access to all Medium armor and shields right out of the gate. This protection is excellent because your job as a cleric is to run straight into the center of the action to be in range to aid your allies or strike your foes as needed.

REASONS TO PLAY A CLERIC:

- You are good at many things: you can sling spells and enter melee without breaking a sweat.
- Everyone wants you in their party (especially if you prepare healing spells).
- Roleplaying a connection to a god can be extremely satisfying.

COMBAT CRASH COURSE

There are many different ways to handle a cleric, so what do you focus on in combat? Before anything else, you need to set yourself up for success. Clerics have many tools at their disposal, and here are a couple of suggestions to make sure you can use them.

GO THE DISTANCE

Clerics have a very juicy spell list. They've got great healing options, some solid damage options, and sweet buff/debuff abilities at their disposal. To be the best cleric you can be, you need to be constantly aware of where your allies and foes are. Being able to touch your dying tank or to stay within range to blast a beam of light is critical to your party's success. The best way to do this is to get right into the center of the action as quickly as possible. Clerics get proficiency in Medium armor and a shield emblazoned with a holy symbol for a very good reason. So suit up and stay precisely the distance you need from your barbarian to heal them for the tenth time while they chop away at demons.

CONTINGENCY PLANS

Playing a cleric is sort of like being everybody's mom. You have a spell to solve just about every problem. This versatility makes you a powerhouse on the playing field, but it can also be incredibly stressful during combat. The best thing you can do as a cleric is to always have contingency plans in place. Before your turn, think about what you ideally want to do. Next, think about what you might have to do if one of your allies gets torn to pieces. Finally, think about what you might do if hell (literally) breaks loose. See what I'm getting at here? To play a cleric well, you have to be ready to roll with the punches because you are likely the only party member who can stop a bad situation from getting worse.

LEVEL-UP PICKS

To be a killer cleric, you have to decide your role in the party and lean into it. Here are some level-up tricks to keep in mind.

BE VERY PICKY

I'm just going to say it. There are a lot of subpar domain options you can stumble into as a cleric. When choosing your domain, it is easy to get tempted



by a sweet spell list. However, you should ignore the spell list and decide based on the Channel Divinity feature. Channel Divinity is your cool cleric card to pull out to shake things up, and it is the most crucial aspect to inform your character build. You will get access to amazing spells as a cleric, whatever you choose, so ensure that Channel Divinity is a fantastic option for the role you want to play.

FIND GOD

As a cleric, you technically don't have to worship a god to get your powers. However, the fun story interactions that come up when your cleric has a strong relationship with a divine being are well worth the choice. You and your GM are going to have a

lot more fun if you pick a god appropriate to your campaign and lean into your relationship with them. Having divine conversations, visiting specific temples, or unraveling bits of lore is so much more fun when your faith points in a clear direction.

FLAVOR SAVOR

Consider these flavorful choices to get your holy on:

- Get the party started with the Beer divine domain (see *Deep Magic*).
- Clerics can use an emblem as their holy symbol to cast spells, which means you can get creative with where you put your divine mark. A cool helmet, a tattoo, or whatever you like. It's a chance to get creative!

DRAFT A DYNAMITE DRUID

I almost always have at least one druid in my party. I'm not sure what it is about this class that speaks to so many, but their appeal just can't be denied. Druids have an impressive spell list with healing, utility, and damage capabilities in even measure. They have solid armor and weapon proficiencies to keep themselves alive. And of course, on top of it all, they can turn into animals. Druids in 5th Edition have had a rocky design road, but they can be an excellent match for both new and experienced players with a little bit of research.

ROLE OF THE DRUID

Druids have a great deal of freedom in what role they fill in an adventuring party. If a party doesn't have a standard healing class, druids can fit into that category nicely. If healing is already covered, they can become DPS (damage per second) machines with their killer selection of blasting spells. If they go all-in on their wild shape features, druids can even hold down combat as the party tank. The key to being an awesome druid is to work together with your party to figure out the role you need to play.

Druids also cover a strong adventuring base: the ability to interact with nature. It is shocking how often the ability to talk to animals or teleport through trees saves the day. At its heart, this is a game about stepping into the unknown and you are way more prepared to do so with the scout-like talents of a druid at your back.



REASONS TO PLAY A DRUID

- Plants and animals love you. If you are a nature buff in real life, you can use all of that to create a satisfying in-game druid experience.
- Your spells shatter the earth, summon storms, and create tidal waves. You will never feel weak as a druid.
- You can fill a bunch of different roles in a party. You are the Swiss Army knife of classes.

COMBAT CRASH COURSE

Druids are another one of those classes that requires a pretty solid understanding of everything you can do. You have many options in your bag, so figuring out your go-to combinations is critical for laying down that prime natural wrath.

MASTER WILD SHAPE

Wild shape is the big druid feature that sets them apart from being exactly like other casters. Unfortunately, it is also the most confusing part of the class with its gigantic block of text description. Here is a quick summary of the little details that will help you tremendously with wild shape:

- Pick out a couple of wild shape stat blocks that you understand and want to use BEFORE combat ever comes up. This way, you'll be ready to do your best.
- You can maintain concentration on a spell while wild shaped, but you can't cast spells. This means that before you transform, you should always cast an ongoing druid spell like *call lightning* or *moonbeam* to maximize your damage output.
- Transforming can keep you from dying. It is a way to give yourself temporary hit points and run the heck away. This is an excellent final option if you find yourself in trouble and out of healing spells.
- For most druid subclasses, using wild shape to deal damage becomes irrelevant at higher levels. However, with just a bit of creativity, wild shape remains useful outside of combat at all levels. Wild shape makes you a great scout, provides excellent disguises, and even allows you to carry around other party members as a mount.

CONCENTRATE!

Druids have many powerful spells at their disposal, and a ton of them are concentration spells. You will almost always want to start combat casting a concentration spells that give you round to round benefits. Once that spell is launched, you can turn to your other epic options. So always plan to kick things off with something like *call lightning*, *moonbeam*, or one of your summon spells. Timing is everything for you to maximize your potential.

LEVEL-UP PICKS

When playing a druid, you have to identify what your party needs you to do most (or what you love to do most) and pick your options accordingly. Here are some level-up tricks to keep in mind.

PAY ATTENTION TO WILD SHAPE

With almost every druid subclass, using wild shape to turn into different animals in combat is the worst

option. When you choose your subclass, pay attention to what you will be doing with your wild shape at higher levels. If the answer is "nothing," it may not be the best subclass to pick.

DON'T MULTICLASS

Druid is one of the few classes that can hold its own without any help from multiclassing. If you stick with a pure druid build, you become a powerhouse so quickly. So resist the temptation and stick with druid! I promise that your spell list will provide all the incentive you need to stay put.

FLAVOR SAVOR

Consider these flavorful choices to help you fight for mother nature:

- If you want to stomp face as a literal tree, check out the Circle of Oaks option (see *Deep Magic*).
- If you love the idea of influencing others with your fantastic smell, check out the Circle of Roses option (see *Deep Magic*).

FORGE A FABULOUS FIGHTER

You'll hear many jokes about fighters being the most basic character option possible. While you can undoubtedly play a basic fighter, there is just so much more potential to unlock with this class than most folks realize. A fighter is an excellent option for beginners as well as experienced players interested in exploring the advanced combat options baked into the game.

ROLE OF THE FIGHTER

There are so many different ways to build a fighter, but at the end of the day, your role is to be good at combat. You can make your fighter a deadly ranged character, a death-dealing tank, a WWE wrestler, a military general, the list goes on and on. All your class options are designed to make you better at dealing damage with the weapon of your choice.

There is a reason so many of the pop culture heroes we love are fighters. Fighters are dependable, they are respected across cultures, and they are the cornerstone of combat survival. Plus, they are one of the only classes that can attack a dragon with a sword and live to tell the tale. Fighters get all the bragging rights.

REASONS TO PLAY A FIGHTER

- Everything you do looks like a scene from an action movie.
- You can use any weapon you want and use it better than anyone else.
- You get so many ability score increases and extra attacks!

COMBAT CRASH COURSE

There is a lot of diversity when it comes to the way people run fighters in combat. A lot of options depend on what type of weapons you end up wielding. A longbow fighter will likely have a very different combat strategy than a greatsword fighter. That being said, there are some general points to remember that are helpful to all fighters.

HIT EM FAST

Fighters live to cut down foes. Your job is to get into position and start doling out damage as quickly as possible. The best tool in your arsenal to bring the pain is your ability to action surge. Action surge gives you a whole additional round of attacks, so you want to use it as soon as you know you can hit your enemy. Don't be shy about popping these abilities early. The average combat lasts only 3 rounds. So take this lesson to heart: the best defense is a good offense.

KNOW YOUR OPTIONS

Did you know that there are a ton of things you can do in combat other than moving and attacking? Most people don't. Even players with lots of experience usually don't remember trusty action like Disengage, Help, Hide, Ready, or Use an Object. And don't even get me started on how people never utilize super moves like grappling, shoving, running for cover. What I'm getting at here is that you have so many more options than you think you do. As a fighter, you are the best suited to pull off all the additional options "hidden" within the game. If you ever feel bored during combat while playing a fighter, I guarantee you aren't using your full potential.

LEVEL-UP PICKS

When playing a fighter, you have to ensure that you have a way to deal wicked damage, hit (almost) every time, and be able to survive heavy hits. Here are some level-up tricks to keep in mind to achieve those goals.

TAKE FEATS

Using feats is technically an optional rule, but it shouldn't be. If your GM doesn't use feats, you should ask them to consider them for your fighter. Taking feats instead of ability score increases is the best way to get awesome quickly. Feats help you specialize your abilities to wield your weapon of choice more effectively, and they can help cover some defensive gaps (better saves against magic effects—yes, please).

GET MAGICAL

There's one big fighter roadblock that you need to keep in mind as you grow in power. At higher levels, most monsters are immune to nonmagical damage. Ideally,



you will get your hands on magic weapons, but you might need to invest in feats or class options to bring a little magic to your blows. Stay alert for opportunities to get a little magic in your combat right from the get-go to save yourself a headache later.

FLAVOR SAVOR

Consider flavorful choices to help you beat baddies:

- If you want to mix a little magic into your martial training, check out the Prescient Knight subclass (see *Deep Magic*).
- Get creative with your weapon selection! There are so many great 3rd-party (or homebrewed) weapons out there. Do a little research and mix things up. Don't be afraid to make an acrobat with killer cartwheels or use a whip/trident combo like the gladiators of old. Just make sure to okay any new weapons with your GM!

MAKE A MARVELOUS MONK

Monks are a class that people seem to love or hate. There is no question that the monk is one of the most powerful classes in 5th edition, but running one to perfection can be quite tedious. I'm not going to lie to you, reader, monks are my least favorite class. Despite that, however, I will give you all the tips and tricks to run these karate kids as efficiently as possible. I would not recommend new players start with monks, but this article will break down what to do if the spirit moves you.

ROLE OF THE MONK

Monks are very direct in their intentions. They exist to deal a bunch of damage and deal it fast. They are the champions of pure DPS (damage per second), and there is no way around that. Monks cannot wear armor, which makes them subpar tanks. They don't have any access to utility magic, so they don't bring much to the table outside of combat. They live to bring the pain, and honestly, that's all they need to focus on because they do it so well. In combat, they run in, make their punches, and repeat.



REASONS TO PLAY A MONK

- You get to subdue your foes with awesome martial arts. No weapons required!
- You don't have to worry about keeping track of equipment because you don't need any.
- You get so many passive bonuses. You will become the fastest and most resistant and most bulletproof character in your party without doing anything.

COMBAT CRASH COURSE

As mentioned above, combat tactics for you are pretty straightforward. Reach your foes, hit them as many times as you can, and if you have the opportunity, get out of the way so you can do it all again next round.



SPENDING KI POINTS

The only tricky thing about monk strategy is managing your ki points. Your ki points are a resource you can use to transform your standard “one extra hit” with a bonus action into something more extraordinary. As you level, you will quickly gain more ki points than you will ever need, so make sure to spend them early and often! You get your ki points back on a short rest, so you should spend a ki point every single round of combat. If you can’t spend a ki point to get two extra strikes with Flurry of Blows, you should be using it to take the Dodge action with Patient Defense. If you are too far from the action, you should spend a ki point for Step of the Wind. There is no reason not to burn through those points quickly (remember, most combats last only three rounds)! When you get to higher levels, spamming your ki points to make Stunning Strikes is your key to victory (beware that your GM will become justifiably exasperated).

DON'T FORGET YOUR PASSIVE ABILITIES!

Monks collect a smorgasbord of passive abilities as they level. I’m referring to things like Deflect Missiles, Slow Fall, Evasion, Purity of Body, and so on. These are all abilities that give you an advantage when something happens to you. Keep a big ol’ highlighted or bulleted list of these abilities handy. Know what you can do, so you can survive and not be that guy who says, “Oh wait, that won’t affect me,” after your GM has spent time adding up 20d6 damage. Know these abilities inside and out. Do whatever you have to do to remember them.

LEVEL-UP PICKS

There is not much to worry about when leveling as a monk since your base abilities make you incredibly powerful right from the get-go and scale beautifully all on their own. But here are a few things to keep in mind for a more well-rounded gaming experience.

CHOOSE YOUR SUBCLASS WISELY

There are some real stinkers out there for Monastic Traditions. Subclasses that sound cool may not be the best choice in terms of power or scaling. Ensure that the subclass you pick doesn’t fight with your core abilities for your action economy or ki points.

FIND WAYS TO BE CREATIVE

It is really easy for monks to have the same backstory: I grew up in a far-away monastery and decided to leave and see the world. Challenge yourself and come up with a new spin! Work on the backstory of your monastery and what its purpose is. Do you

have a connection to a divine entity? If not, what is the code you live by? Is there a better reason you left the monastery than “just because”? Investing some time in your story and motivations will help you stay interesting alongside the rest of your party.

FLAVOR SAVOR

Consider these flavorful choices to shake up the traditional monk origin story:

- Take a look at some of the weird background options like Fey Hostage or Soul Channeler (see *Deep Magic*).
- Research magic items that would work well for your character and talk to your GM about them. Monks are at their best when they don’t wear armor, and they have a minimal selection of weapons they can use. These limitations can make rewarding monks with magical treasure very difficult. If you find specific types of magic items that would work great with your character, let your GM know! Or if you change GMs often, make sure to keep your ears out whenever items like this come up, and stake your claim when it comes time to divide the treasure among the party members.

PLAY A PERFECT PALADIN

Paladins have been around for the majority of the game’s history. These holy warriors embody the knight in shining armor archetype. Paladins are an incredibly satisfying class to play because they deal massive amounts of damage without being overwhelmingly complicated to play. Paladins also make an excellent choice for a new player because they can be straightforward in their motivations. It’s nice and simple to be the typical good guy. There are a couple of tricky things to remember when playing this class, but once you’ve got those down, you will shine bright like the holy diamond you are.

ROLE OF THE PALADIN

Paladins at their core are damage dealers. With their ability to pile on smite damage to any hit, paladins and monks stand at the top of the dishing-out-pain pyramid. Paladins also make incredible tanks since they can wear the heaviest of armor and wield shields at the same time. And if all those armor proficiencies weren’t enough, they get incredible bonuses to saving throws and can even heal themselves in a pinch. Paladins are truly self-sustained fighting machines.

REASONS TO PLAY A PALADIN

- You dominate the battlefield.
- You feel very powerful but don't have to keep track of a million different spells.
- You literally make everyone else better just by standing next to them. The bonuses everyone gets from your aura abilities are straight-up amazing.

COMBAT CRASH COURSE

With killer AC and champion saving throws, paladins don't have to spend too much time worrying about staying alive. All you have to worry about is how best to maximize your damage and how to position yourself in combat so everyone can benefit from your holy auras. Whether you choose to build a Strength-based Paladin or a Dexterity-based Paladin, you have to ensure that you can get into the center of the action as soon as possible and stay there. Once you're in the thick of it, it's time to start smacking away!

SPELL SLOT ECONOMY

The trickiest thing about running a paladin is managing your spell slot economy. Paladins have fewer spell slots and fewer spell options than full-casting classes like the cleric. Your best paladin feature is your ability to smite, which burns up your precious few spell slots to add massive amounts of damage to your regular attacks. It is very important that you keep an eye on your spell slots and make sure you don't burn them all before getting to smite the Big Bad. It can be tempting as a paladin to use your spell slots on some of the cool divine options out there, but I assure you, 9 times out of 10, you don't want to use your spell slots for anything other than smiting. As a rule, it's a good idea to hold back one slot at most in case you have to save the day with a heal or restoration, but that's about it. Leave all the magic tasks to full casters. You are here to slay foes!

INVEST IN CHARISMA

Everyone jokes that Charisma is a dump stat. You cannot afford to let that be true. While Charisma isn't going to help you much with your spellcasting (remember, we mostly want to be smiting with spell slots), it will buff your aura abilities down the line. Allies who stand close to you get all kinds of bonuses from your Charisma modifier. I cannot stress enough that this is one of the best benefits in the entire game, so don't be a chump—be charismatic instead. Even better, you benefit from your own auras! Everyone



wins when you invest in Charisma right from character creation, even if it feels like it's not worth it at the moment.

LEVEL-UP PICKS

Paladins are another class that scales pretty nicely just the way it is, so you don't have to be super worried about picking the “wrong” options. That said, here are a few things to keep in mind as you level-up your shiny knight.

FIND SOMETHING FOR YOUR BONUS ACTION

While paladin class abilities are extraordinary, they do leave one particular action economy blind spot: the bonus action. You must find something awesome to do with your bonus action as a paladin. This can come

from a couple of different places, but you're likely to get something useful by picking a great subclass or picking up a cool magic item. You might also want to consider multiclassing with a couple of levels of some other class. Whatever it is, make sure you keep your eye out for the best way to maximize your turns.

GET AHEAD

The second ability you need to get a leg up is movement. From 1st level, you need to consider the best way to get to where you are needed in a hurry. Once again, choosing the right subclass or items could give you a way to do this. It's a good idea to think about building your character to be effective at walking ahead of the party, so you are the first one into the fray. This might mean forsaking the heaviest armor for a less noisy option or investing in a great Stealth score. Think about how your character fits into the grand scheme of adventuring and make your build moves early.

FLAVOR SAVOR

- Consider mixing it up by being a stealthy paladin with the Oath of Thunder (see *Deep Magic*).
- Research some nonstandard fighting styles and see what interesting builds you can accomplish with feats. Paladins are one of the only classes that can pull off mounted combat, so give weapons like lance a second look. Being made for combat doesn't mean you have to be just hacking, slashing, and repeating.

ROLL UP A RAD RANGER

Rangers have had a special place in the heart of fantasy from the moment *Lord of the Rings* introduced resident hero Aragorn, son of Arathorn. While no one can deny that the idea of a ranger is very cool, this class has had a rocky mechanical road through the different iterations of the game. With lots of different options to dip into, the ranger has the potential to be played in a wide variety of ways. I don't recommend new players start with the ranger because in 5th Edition it is challenging to build a ranger that scales well through your adventures. However, if you are willing to do a little homework, you can still create the lone-wolf tracker of your dreams.

ROLE OF THE RANGER

Rangers, as written in the rules, are pretty unfocused. There are a lot of different paths to follow when building your character. Rangers get a little attention on their fighting capabilities, they get a little attention on their pure utility capabilities, and they get a little attention on spellcasting. Ultimately, you have to commit to a firm choice about how your ranger will play, or you will find



yourself lackluster at everything. Your ranger has a lot of potential to be a great DPS source in combat if you focus on ranged weapons or sneaky two-weapon fighting. If your party has absolutely no other option for a tank, rangers can be squeezed into that role as well with their solid hit dice and dexterous capabilities. With a little help from feats and multiclass levels, your ranger can even be a viable nature-themed spellcaster if you really want to push outside the box.

REASONS TO PLAY A RANGER

- Rangers easily lend themselves to having strong personalities and wicked cool backstories to roleplay. They are a great class to play if you're a little shy and prefer to roleplay a strong/silent type.
- You get access to cool nature magic but don't have to worry about looking through a gigantic spell list like druids do.
- If you enjoy thinking about tactical advantages, you will have a field day utilizing your passive ranger abilities.

COMBAT CRASH COURSE

The big choice to make as a ranger is what kind of weapons you wield. While there are several different options available to enhance fighting styles, the clear winners are ranged combat or two-weapon fighting. With either option, your job in combat is to get yourself into the best position to deal consistent damage without pulling the attention of heavy-hitting creatures.

USE FINESSE

Dexterity is arguably the best ability score in the game, and for you, that is even more true. Rangers have many abilities that affect mobility, and it makes sense to back those up by investing as much as you can in your Dexterity score. With this philosophy in mind, it is best to resist the temptation to use Strength-based weapons as a ranger. You do technically have the option to make Strength-based weapons viable, but most of the time, you'll regret it if you do. While finesse weapons like scimitars and short swords might have slightly smaller damage die, your average damage will be far better in the long run by utilizing your precious Dexterity score. So grab an arsenal of finesse martial weapons and ranged weapons and prepare for a good time. Trust me on this one.

KNOW THE TERRAIN

Rangers pick up several abilities that give them advantages while in certain types of terrain. These interactions between your abilities and the game setting are unique to rangers and therefore a little difficult to get a handle on. New GMs, in particular, may not always be clear about whether or not there is mud available to use for your Hide in Plain Sight feature or if the jungle floor is considered difficult terrain. The onus to ask questions about what the battlefield looks like is on you. Many of your class benefits are conditional, so don't feel bad about asking questions when you need to.

SECOND-STRING CASTER

Unless you have worked to build your ranger unconventionally, you should never be the first person in the party to cast spells. Rangers get very few spell slots and don't have access to an extensive list of spells, so you must use them wisely. And while Wisdom-based skills like Perception are important, you should be putting more into your Dexterity whenever you get the chance. Favoring your Dexterity is much better in the long run but means that you are not going to be wielding your Wisdom-based spells as well as clerics or druids (nor should you). With this in mind, it's rarely worth it for you to cast any spells that require a saving throw. Saving your precious few slots to cast spells that enhance your abilities is the best way to go.

LEVEL-UP PICKS

As mentioned above, when leveling your ranger, you have to be pretty picky to make sure they are the best they can be. Just make sure to stay informed on your options, and you'll be good to go! Here are a couple of other thoughts to consider while leveling your nature pal.

FUTURE PROOF

Right off the bat, rangers have to make a couple of big choices about what kind of terrain they excel in and what kind of monsters they are best at fighting. Before you commit to this decision, it is extremely important that you consult your GM. There is nothing more disappointing than choosing to play a forest ranger and finding out in session one you will be playing a campaign set exclusively in a sprawling city. Let your GM know what kind of ranger you would like to play, and ask if your ideas would be a good fit for the campaign. It might seem weird to have this conversation, but I promise both you and your GM will have a better time playing a game where your ranger is useful.

FLAVOR SAVOR

- Ramp up your ranger's backstory with a new archetype like the Griffon Scout or the Vampire Slayer (see *Deep Magic*).

Ask your GM to consider 3rd-party content for your ranger. A lot of brilliant people have invented new class options, subclasses, and spells to make rangers awesome. Get into the forest of the Internet and hunt around!

RALLY A RUTHLESS ROGUE

If you are familiar with the fantasy genre, I'm sure you are familiar with rogues. These tricky characters are famous for their abilities to lie, steal, and deliver maiming attacks their enemies rarely see coming. Like skullduggery itself, playing a rogue well requires a great deal of patience and the ability to assess your options quickly. Running a rogue to their full potential requires a solid understanding of the game rules, and for that reason, I don't often recommend them as a starting class for new players. That said, if you are willing to get a little dirty learning how to exploit the rules, you will make a fine rogue regardless of your experience level.

ROLE OF THE ROGUE

Rogues are a party's secret weapon, literally. A rogue is at their best blitzing around the battlefield, positioning themselves to dish out maximum damage at the most critical of moments. While they deal excellent damage, rogues aren't meant to take hits, so they will typically find themselves performing hit-and-run tactics while the others in their party tank the bad guys. Rogues also play a key role outside of combat, being the most qualified to sneak, spy, and scout without attracting undue attention. A rogue's skills with Investigation and Sleight of Hand make them shine in dungeons full of traps and locked doors.

REASONS TO PLAY A ROGUE

- You are so good at sneaking. You honestly put *invisibility* to shame just by existing.
- In every combat, you get to play tactical mastermind, setting up elaborate moves for a major payoff.
- You are the master of dungeons, which is half of the game, right?



COMBAT CRASH COURSE

Crafting an optimal build for your rogue is not the hardest part of this class. If you pay attention to your class abilities, it becomes pretty clear what kind of equipment you need to use. The most difficult part of running a rogue is understanding how to get the most out of your class features.

GET THE ADVANTAGE

The biggest struggle rogues face is making sure they can use their sneak attack every round. Sneak attack is the bread and butter of the rogue, it is the reason you deal good damage, and you need to understand how it works. If you aren't getting to use your sneak attack every single round, you are doing something wrong. To get your sneak attack, you need to have advantage on your attack roll or meet a certain set of specific conditions. Memorize all the ways you can get advantage, and you will be slaying in no time. The most sure-fire way to get your sneak attack each round

is to only attack enemies engaged in a fight with your fellow players. The exception that grants you sneak attack as long as you hit a target within 5 feet of one of your allies will save your bacon time after time. Learn to love teamwork, and you will do just fine.

BOB AND WEAVE

Rogues get a cadre of abilities that help their survivability. Features like evasion, uncanny dodge, and expertise are absolute lifesavers. Unfortunately, remembering to use them can be a struggle. I don't know how many times I have calculated massive amounts of damage only to have a player suddenly remember that they could have avoided it all a couple of turns later. Study the heck out of these abilities, and do whatever you need to do to remember their benefits if they creep up in the heat of combat. Your GM and your party will thank you if you use these abilities seamlessly. Learn to watch your own back because the other people at your table will not remember to remind you (nor should they have to).

BE CUNNING

Your cunning action ability is one of the most powerful and under-utilized tools. With your amazing ability to move out of danger, you should be using your bonus action every single turn of combat. If you aren't doing something tricky with your bonus action, use it to Disengage or Hide and get that heat off you! Seriously, please do it. If you play your cards right, you should never start your turn within the range of enemy melee attacks.

LEVEL-UP PICKS

If you follow the cues and make sure to use appropriate equipment, leveling your rogue will be very straightforward. The challenge for you will be finding the right combination of feats and subclass features that enhance the things you do well. Here are a couple of things to consider while death-proofing your surprise master.

DO MORE THAN STEAL

If your character is only motivated by picking pockets and stealing treasure, you (and the rest of your party) are going to become a boring trope character really quick. I recommend that you figure out some kind of personal journey for your rogue to go on. Learning to use skullduggery to achieve something more significant than greed is a very compelling narrative. Explore your options and find rules to support your development as a character!

FLAVOR SAVOR

- If you want to explore a broader range of subclass options, check out the duelist, fixer, and whisper archetypes in the *Midgard Heroes Handbook*.
- You are good at learning things, so why not get creative with tool proficiencies? Since you stand a good chance of actually mastering new skills, come up with innovative ways to use game sets, cooking utensils, or musical instruments.

SUMMON A SUPER SORCERER

Historically, roleplaying games have struggled to define what sets a sorcerer apart from the bookish wizard. We have landed in a place that makes a sorcerer's charisma front and center. While this class has limited choices in what spells they can cast, they have greater mastery over the subtle aspects of spells and can shape them through inner will rather than routine practice. Frankly, this subtle magic manipulation makes this





class very fiddly to play. Because playing a sorcerer well requires extensive forethought about action economy and a deep understanding of magical mechanics, I do not recommend this class for new players.

ROLE OF THE SORCERER

Sorcerers are traditional spellcasters through and through. But the subclass options and spells available only work if you stay out of the central conflict. Your spell list as a sorcerer is smaller and more jam-packed with heavy-hitting damage spells than utility options. You can use metamagic to enhance your spells and reload missing slots with ease. These qualities all add up to making sorcerers great in a fight as long as they avoid taking hits. Sorcerers are damage-dealing fiends, but they don't have much going on outside of combat (mechanically, anyway). So party on. Your role is to be a big, magical lightning rod!

REASONS TO PLAY A SORCERER

- Your Charisma score and sorcerous origin story make all sorcerers painfully cool.
- You don't have to deal with a gigantic spell list, and you pick from a simple collection of highly effective blasting spells.
- Your ability to generate spell slots means that you can keep fighting long after other casters have run out of juice.

COMBAT CRASH COURSE

Running a sorcerer optimally in combat is not an easy task. To get the most out of your features, you have to keep several moving pieces in mind and pay extra attention to your resources. While tricky, mastering the ways of a sorcerer makes you feel pretty godlike.

HOW TO BREAK THE RULES

Metamagic is the core class ability of the sorcerer. With metamagic, you can transform and enhance your spells to create potent magical effects. You are not limited to the spell rules as written the same way other classes are. However, such freedom comes with a big caveat. To effectively break the rules of magic means you first have to understand how the rules work. You can't really break the rules if you have no idea what the rules are. I recommend you read the spellcasting sections of the core books and then reread them and take notes. In particular, pay attention to rules that limit how many spells you can cast per turn and how cantrips get mixed up in all that. You need to know what a touch spell is, what the different spell

ranges mean, how to calculate spell attacks, and how spell saves work. Learning these things sounds like a drag, but it is worth it. I can't effectively communicate how many times I have seen players gleefully choose a metamagic effect and then get absolutely heartbroken when they learn mid-session the effect doesn't work the way they thought it did. Learn the rules to break the rules. You just have to do it, friend.

ECONOMY 101

Action economy is so crucial for you. Sorcerers are made to have action-packed turns. If you aren't spending most of your turns taking both an action and a bonus action, you are not living up to your full sorcerous potential. With excellent metamagic options like Quicken Spell and your ability to convert sorcery points into spell slots, your bonus actions are where you shine. And speaking of sorcery points, that is another resource you have to keep at the front of your mind. You will have a lot more wiggle room with points at higher levels, but at lower levels, you have to be a little more tactical. Being able to recover sorcery points only during a long rest is pretty harsh, so if you are in for a series of small fights leading up to a big conclusion, it's okay to depend on your damage-dealing cantrips to conserve your strength.

LEVEL-UP PICKS

Sorcerers are another one of the classes that, unfortunately, has some mechanically bogus options. When leveling your sorcerer, you have to consider your choices thoroughly to make sure you will be able to do what you want effectively. Here are a couple of things to consider while tuning your arcane powerhouse.

MAXIMIZE YOUR METAMAGIC

The biggest pitfall with sorcerers comes from choosing the wrong metamagic options. You only get four options if you reach the maximum level, and unless you have a GM willing to play by optional rules, you can never swap them out. When choosing your options, make sure to ask yourself if your choice will still be good 5 levels from now, 10 levels from now, and so on.

CONSIDER MULTICLASSING

Sorcerers are a great candidate for multiclassing. The sorcerer class capstone 20th-level ability is, unfortunately, pretty weak compared to other classes. Once you have enough firepower, you have plenty of freedom to explore other class options. Mixing sorcerer with other non-casting classes, in particular, can create a very well-rounded play experience.

FLAVOR SAVOR

- If you want to explore more sorcerous origins, check out Aristocratic, Elemental Essence, and Farseer (see *Deep Magic*).
- Check out some of the homebrew or optional rules folks have created to swap out metamagic options and expand spell lists. Just make sure to clear any alternate rules sources with your GM!

WHIP-UP A WINNING WARLOCK

Warlock has seen many design changes since its initial debut, but it has remained one of the most beloved classes through them all. Warlocks get to spam the best damage cantrip in the game, and they get a whole bunch of extra flavor mechanics to sprinkle on top. Warlocks can be super simple to play if you build them that way or more complicated if you're interested in playing around with the massive number of option combinations you can select. For this reason, warlocks aren't the optimal choice for new players, but if you're willing to read through all the options carefully, you'll do just fine.

ROLE OF THE WARLOCK

Warlocks are a little odd compared to the rest of the arcane casters. They have very few spell slots and very few spells known. What they lack in diversity is made up for in their cantrips, though, because they have *eldritch blast*, which is the best damage-dealing cantrip in the game. So warlocks always have a way to deal solid damage in combat. Other than that primary purpose, warlocks can serve various party roles, depending on what class options they pick. Different combinations of features can make warlocks function like a wizard, heal like a cleric, and even tank like a fighter. Your role as a warlock is highly customizable, which is why so many players, both new and veteran, love this class.

REASONS TO PLAY A WARLOCK

- You have many options for building your character, and no two warlocks ever feel quite the same.
- No matter how spent your resources are, you can always come out on top by firing an *eldritch blast*.
- Roleplaying your connection to the patron who fuels your power can be so much fun.

COMBAT CRASH COURSE

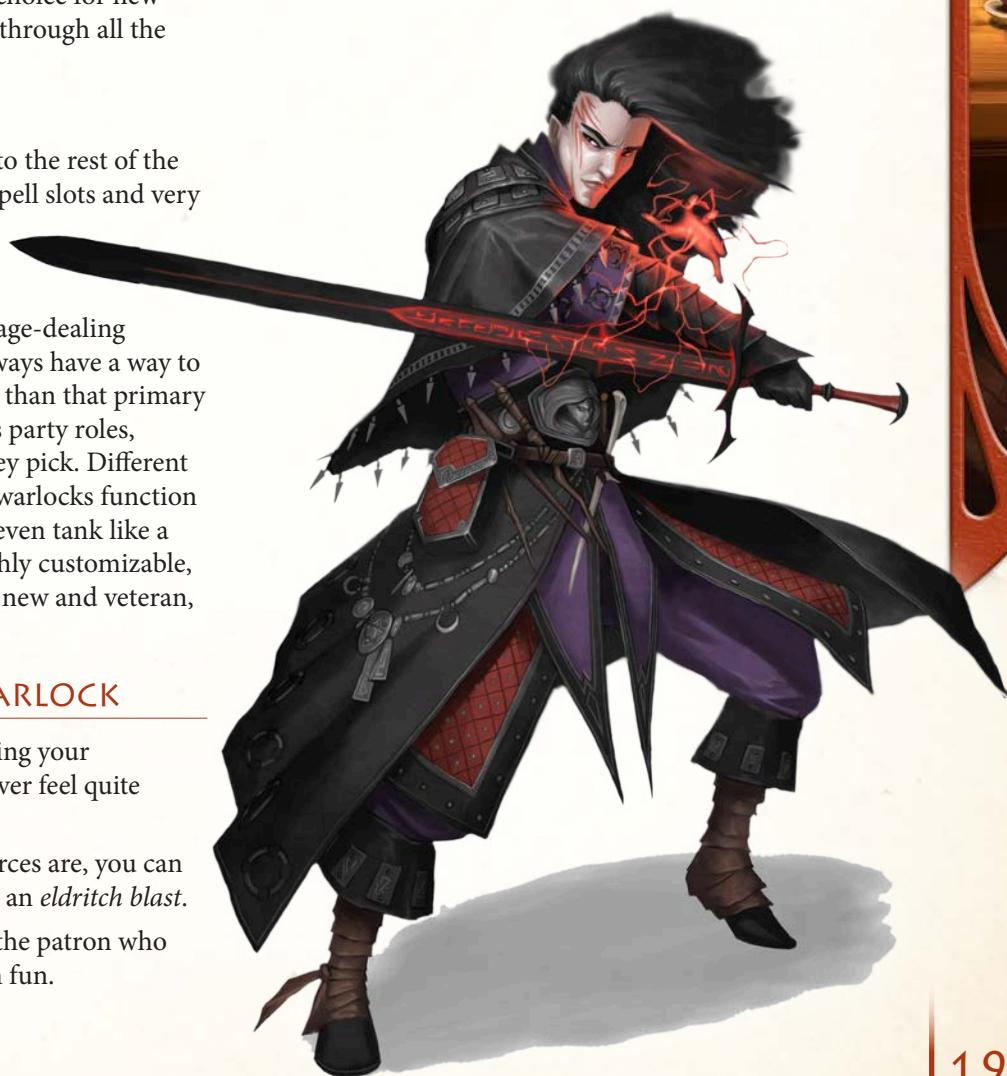
Once you've done the hard part and selected your warlock features, you should have a pretty good idea of where you fit in combat.

GO TO THE SHOOTING RANGE

Unless you have abilities that work in melee, you are best suited to standing as far away as you can get from enemies while remaining within shooting range. The average warlock can take a few punches with their d8 hit dice and armor proficiencies, but that is a stance better left untested. Most turns, you will be firing away with your blast, reserving your precious spell slots to use in case of emergency. So stand in the back and get blasting!

UTILITY SPELLS ONLY

Warlocks have a limited spell list and the fewest number of spell slots of any casting class. This means you have to be incredibly picky about what spells you learn. When you choose your spells, only grab





the ones that will serve a practical purpose. What I mean is don't pick up any spells that just do damage. You can dish out plenty of damage with your sweet cantrip list, so shop for the spells that will get you or your allies out of trouble when an encounter starts to go south. Better yet, plan out what invocations you will take for all your future levels, so you know which spells to take that will compliment your growing abilities. You don't have the wiggle room to learn spells you don't actually need.

LEVEL-UP PICKS

As I've mentioned above, warlocks have so very many choices to make as they level up. This volume can make growing as a warlock a little daunting, so the best strategy is to plan ahead. Here are a couple of things to keep in mind when crafting your eldritch superstar.

GET THE MOST OUT OF YOUR BLAST

Eldritch blast is the cornerstone of the Warlock class, so make sure you have an excellent way to use it. You almost always want to choose at least one invocation that maximizes the ability of your eldritch blast. It is such a good ability, so don't ignore it!

PLAN AHEAD

Warlocks have many micro choices they have to make, including choosing spells, invocations, and mystic arcanum spells at higher levels. It's easy to get lost in all these choices. To make sure you have a well-rounded warlock with enough options, it behooves you to plan ahead. Whenever you level, think about what you're going to pick up at the next couple levels too. Thinking toward the future helps you lock in the synergy that can be easy to miss with this class.

FLAVOR SAVOR

- If you want to see what other patrons are willing to trade a soul for a pact, check out the Genie Lord and the Sibyl in *Deep Magic*.
- Don't be afraid to roleplay! Working with your GM to create a meaningful story around your relationship with your warlock patron is an extremely satisfying part of playing a warlock.

WORK OUT A WONDERFUL WIZARD

When people think of fantasy roleplaying games, I guarantee that a wizard's image is one of the first things that comes to mind. Wizards are the most versatile of all the spellcasting classes and have remained so through the game's history. Wizards immerse themselves in the academic aspects of magic and can learn a mind-blowing amount of spells suited for even the most bizarre of occasions. Wizards are so much fun to play, but they require a lot of reading and sifting through spell information to run effectively. If creative problem-solving and character resource management are things you don't enjoy, you probably want to skip playing a wizard. I often recommend new players choose one of the easier spellcasting classes when first starting, but some people are perfectly suited to play a wizard from the start, so trust your judgment.

ROLE OF THE WIZARD

Wizards have access to the most extensive spell list of any class, and consequently, there are a hundred different ways to play a wizard. When you begin to create your wizard, think about what kind of magic you want to do, informing the role you have in your party. Do you want to use explosive magic to destroy your foes? Do you want to master defensive magic to buff and protect your allies? Do you want to make yourself a capable frontline fighter? Do you want to be the ultimate situational problem solver? All of these options and more are possible when deciding what kind of role you want your wizard to play in combat. I will take a moment to mention that the "standard" wizard model is to stand in the back and fire your spells from a distance. Because wizards have fewer hit points naturally, you have to invest resources in bulking up a wizard if you want to deviate from that standard model.

REASONS TO PLAY A WIZARD

- You have so many more options to solve problems than anyone else.
- With the sheer volume of spells available to you, you get to explore some of the most creative and strange elements the game has to offer.
- Magic is everywhere in this game, and you get to be the expert your party relies on to figure it out.

COMBAT CRASH COURSE

The difficulty of playing a wizard is to cultivate a spell list that allows you to do everything you want to do. Wizards can cover many different offensive and defensive bases, so you need to choose your spells wisely to be effective.

COVER THE BASES

Every level you achieve, you will learn more spells, so your number-one job is to make sure you survive to the next level to learn said spells. Learning which spells are best for you to take at the right times requires a commitment to reading through all your options and assessing how a spell will work when you need it. While it may seem fun to grab a collection of the flashiest spells available, it is easy to regret your choices later when you discover they don't work well for how you play. Selecting the right spells is an art you will get better at with experience.

LEVEL-UP PICKS

Picking new spells is the most challenging part of leveling up your wizard. If you follow the guidelines above, you don't have to worry too much about the other aspects of leveling. So pick the flavorful options that appeal to you! If you are looking for some extra tips, check these out:

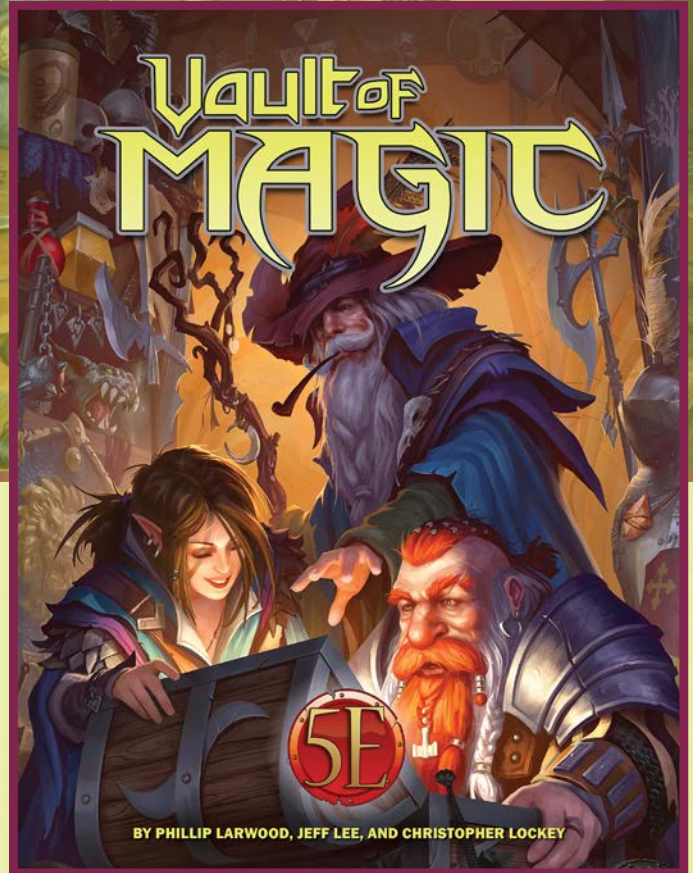
- Make sure you take at least one damage cantrip. That way, you'll always have something to defend yourself with, even if you run out of spell slots.
- Make sure you have at least one solid close-range spell and at least one really long-range spell. This ensures you can keep your options open.
- Make sure you have a mix of spells that use a spell attack roll and spells that require a saving throw. This ensures you have a chance of hitting any enemy.
- Make sure you have a few spells that don't require concentration and at least one really good spell that does require it. This ensures you achieve your full spellcasting potential.
- Cultivate spells that have different casting times. If you have a mix of spells that require a standard action, a bonus action, and a reaction to cast, you will be able to respond to any problem that comes your way.



FLAVOR SAVOR

- Explore some more interesting subclass options by checking out the elementalist and the white necromancer arcane traditions (see *Deep Magic*).
- Don't be afraid to take some feats. Options that allow you to cast your spells more freely or give you some extra hit points as a cushion are helpful compliments to your arcane powers!

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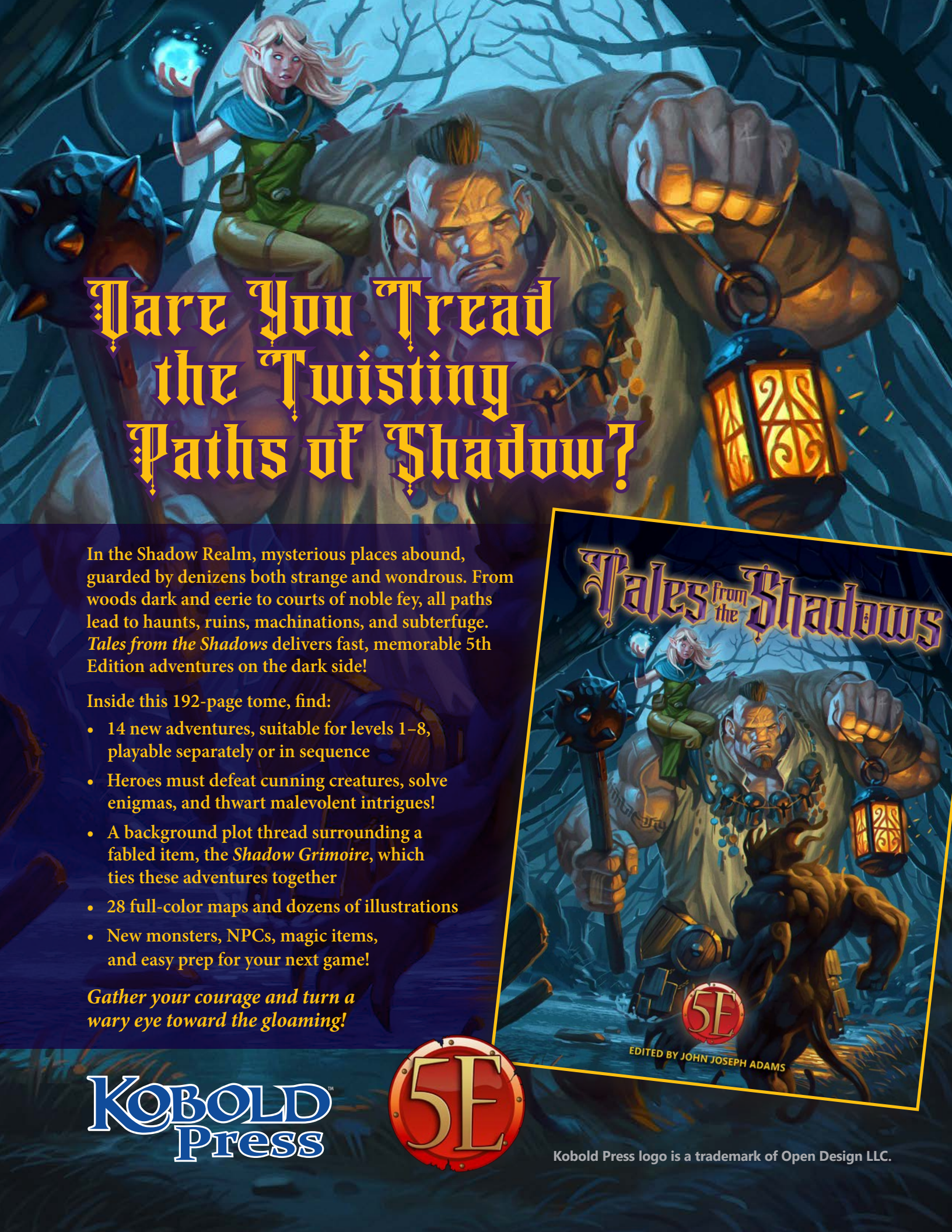
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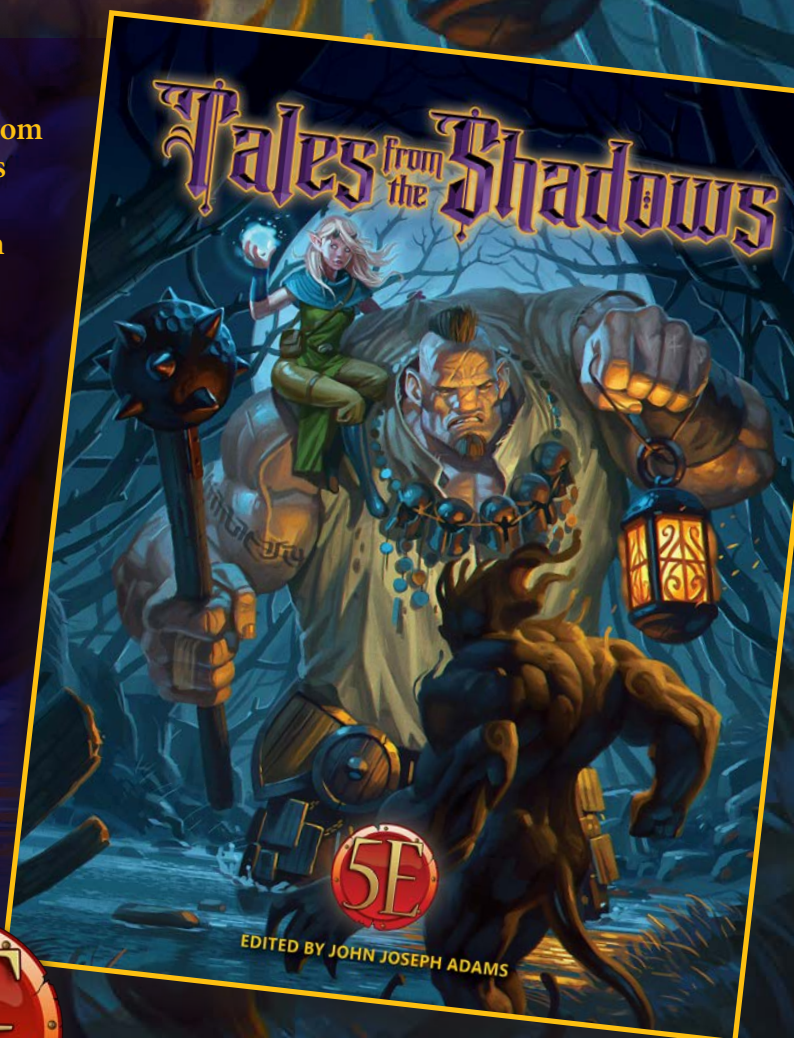
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